

Kazakhstan’s Trade Reorientation and the Structural Shift in Sino–Kazakh Trade (2015–2024)

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Abstract

This paper synthesizes the project evidence on Kazakhstan’s external trade structure and the post-2022 acceleration of trade integration with China. Using existing WTO-based project outputs for 2015–2024, we compare China with Russia and the EU, examine bilateral composition and sectoral asymmetries, and assess the shift from sustained bilateral surpluses to deficits. The evidence indicates that China has moved from a secondary to a co-leading trade partner in Kazakhstan’s comparison set, while trade structure remains asymmetric: Kazakhstan exports commodities and semi-processed materials, but imports increasingly concentrated manufactured goods. The 2023 break in the bilateral balance and high sectoral import concentration imply persistent vulnerability unless diversification and domestic upgrading keep pace with trade expansion.

1 Introduction

Kazakhstan’s external economic strategy is formally multivector, yet the composition of its trade has changed substantially over the last decade. This paper consolidates project outputs into a single narrative with consistent interpretation from Kazakhstan’s perspective.

Unless explicitly stated otherwise, all bilateral statistics are interpreted as follows: exports are goods Kazakhstan sells to China, and imports are goods Kazakhstan buys from China.

2 Data and Scope

The analysis uses existing project tables and figures generated from WTO-oriented bilateral data workflows. The effective annual window in the existing outputs is 2015–2024. No new

data are introduced in this manuscript.

Core source files already present in the repository include:

- `tables/table8_annual_bilateral_trade.csv`
- `tables/table4_multivector_diversification.csv`
- `tables/table2_china_sectoral_breakdown.csv`
- Annotated figures in `figures/fig*_annotated.png`

3 Kazakhstan’s External Trade Structure (Context)

3.1 Overview of Trade Partners

Within the project comparison set (China–Russia–EU), partner shares indicate a rebalanced but still diversified structure. Existing outputs show that China and Russia increased relative weight after 2022, while the EU share declined but remained substantial.

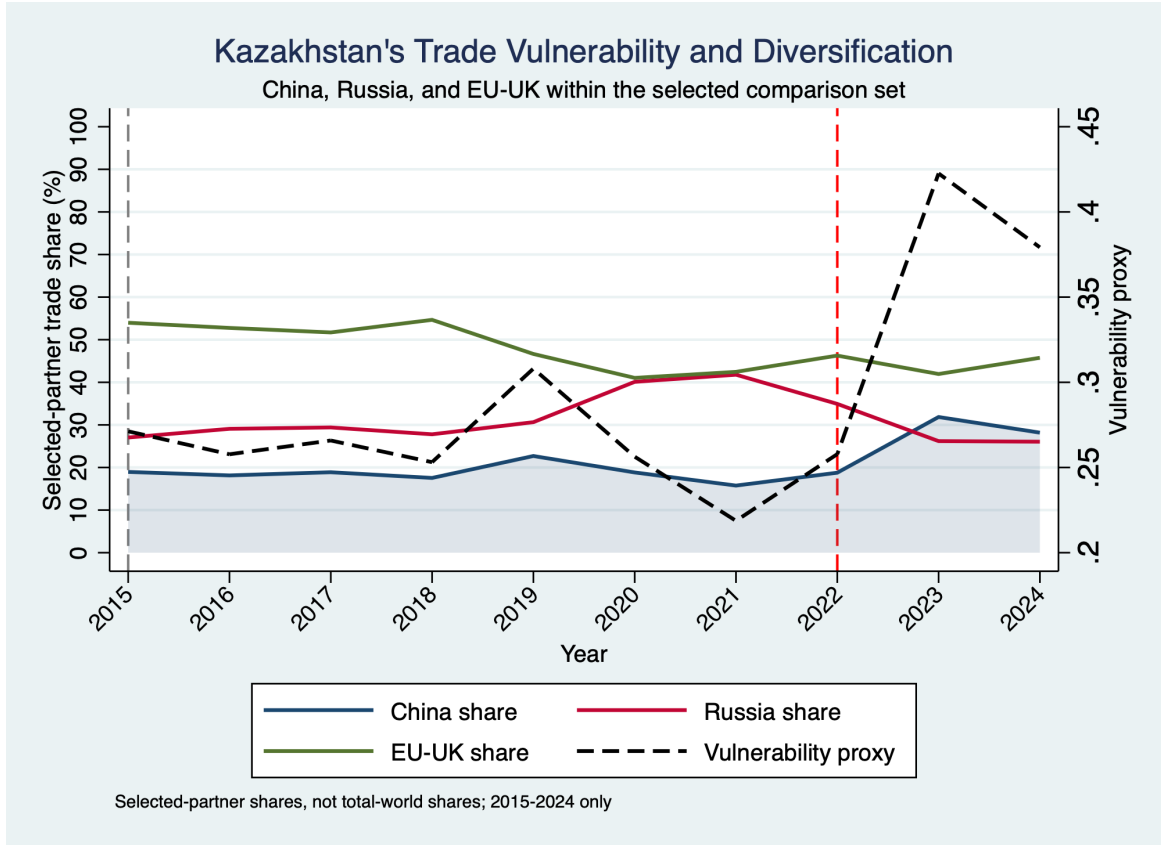


Figure 8: Trade Vulnerability - Multidimensional Framework, 2015-2024
Three vulnerability dimensions worsen simultaneously: sectoral concentration (0.25-0.35 HH), bilateral dependency, and penetration levels (77-90%).
KEY INSIGHT: Multi-dimensional vulnerability indicates cumulative exposure risk across concentration, partner dependency, and import penetration.

Figure 1: Multivector comparison set dynamics (existing project figure).

3.2 Evolution of Partner Shares

The share trajectory supports structural reweighting rather than full replacement of legacy partners. China rises sharply in the late period, especially around the 2023 inflection.

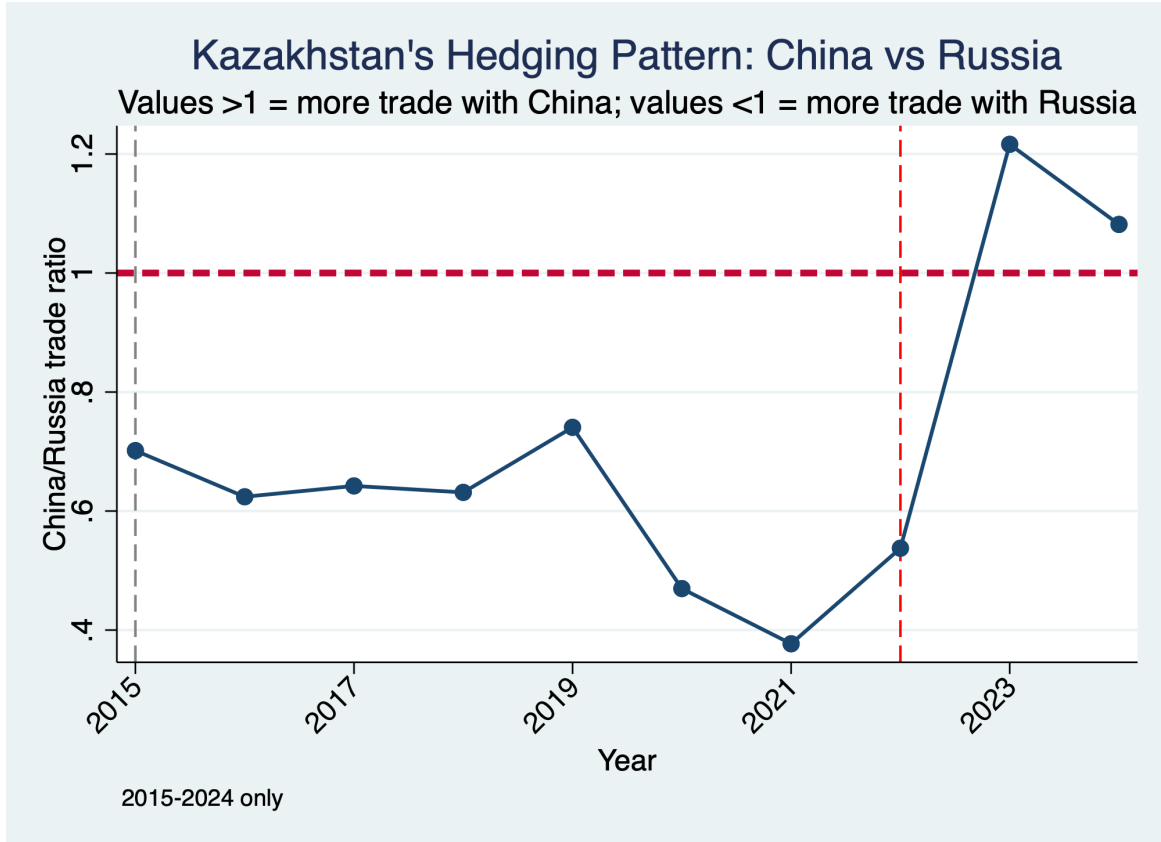


Figure 11: Post-2023 Hedging Behavior - Partner Shares
 China's import share increased from 28.4% (2015-2022) to 30.1% (2023-2024). No diversification to alternative partners occurred.
KEY INSIGHT: Lack of hedging behavior suggests structural entrenchment rather than temporary imbalance.

Figure 2: China–Russia trade orientation and relative shift (existing project figure).

3.3 Basic Export–Import Composition

Bilateral composition differs strongly by partner role. Existing project evidence consistently shows export-heavy engagement with energy-linked channels and increasing import dependence in manufacturing-intensive channels.

4 Structural Features of Sino–Kazakh Trade

4.1 China's Rise as a Leading Partner

The project time-series outputs show that total bilateral trade with China expanded rapidly and reached a new regime in 2023–2024.

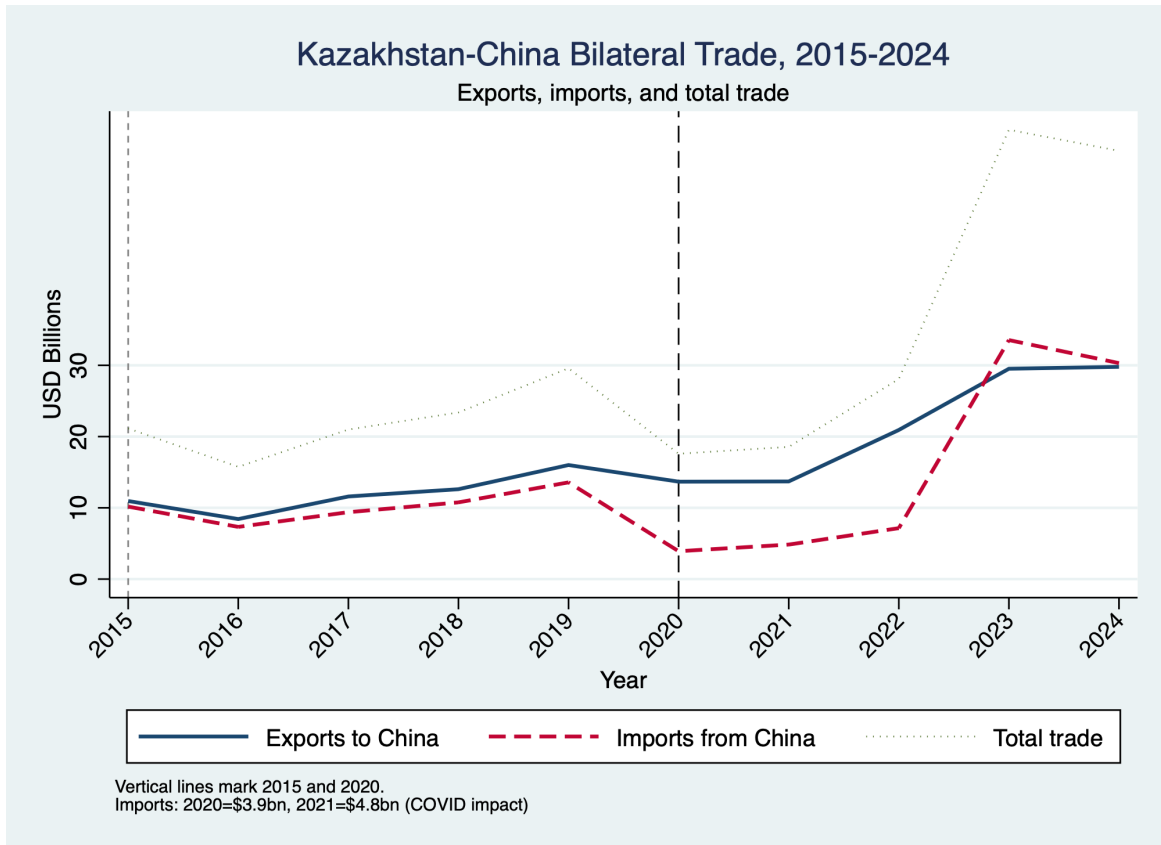


Figure 12: Bilateral Trade Flows - Exports vs Imports, 2015-2024
Exports grew from \$8.4B to \$18.5B (+120%). Imports grew from \$6.2B to \$22.5B (+263%). Lines crossed into deficit in 2023.
KEY INSIGHT: Persistent divergence post-2022 (not cyclical variation) defines the structural shift.

Figure 3: Kazakhstan–China aggregate trade flows, 2015–2024 (existing project figure).

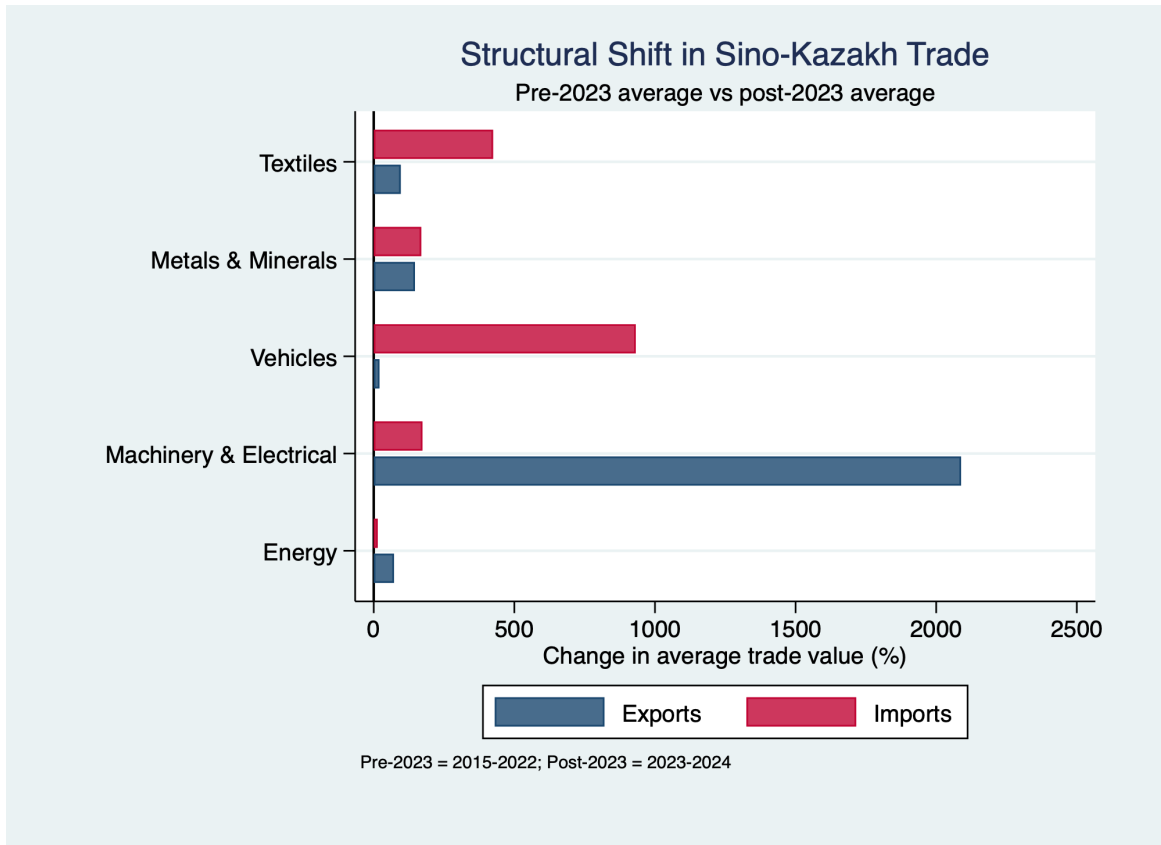


Figure 10: 2023 Structural Shift - Sectoral Before/After Analysis
Machinery shifted from +60.3B average surplus (2015-2022) to -63.4B average deficit (2023-2024). Vehicles shifted from +20.1B to -42.3B deficit.
KEY INSIGHT: -60B sectoral shift explains overall balance reversal; 2024 persistence confirms structural nature.

Figure 4: 2023 structural break in bilateral pattern (existing project figure).

4.2 Sectoral and Product Composition

The trade profile remains asymmetric: exports to China are concentrated in commodities and semi-processed sectors, while imports from China are concentrated in machinery/electrical goods, vehicles, and textiles.

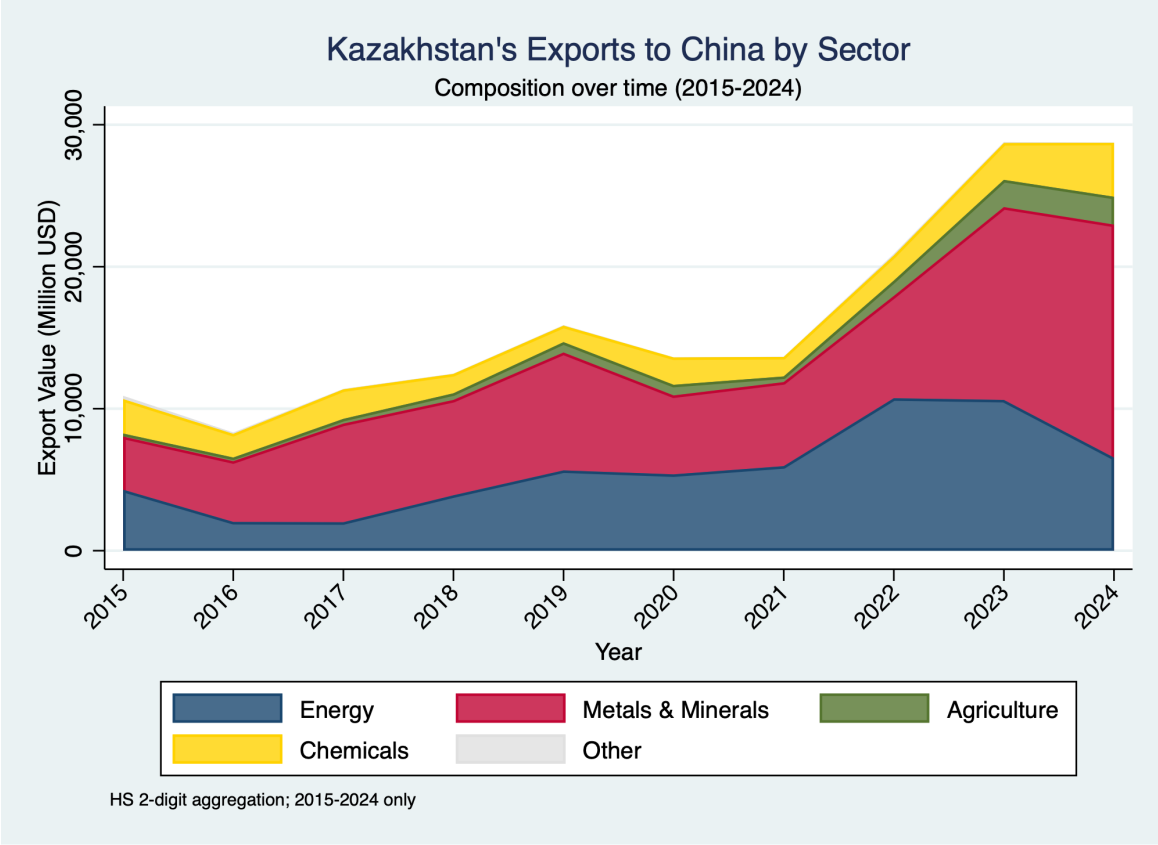


Figure 1: Kazakhstan's Exports to China by Sector, 2015-2024
Energy and metals dominate exports (45% and 35% respectively). Total exports grew 120% from \$8.4B to \$18.5B.
KEY INSIGHT: Commodity-dependent export structure with no significant diversification into manufactured goods.

Figure 5: Export composition to China (existing project figure).

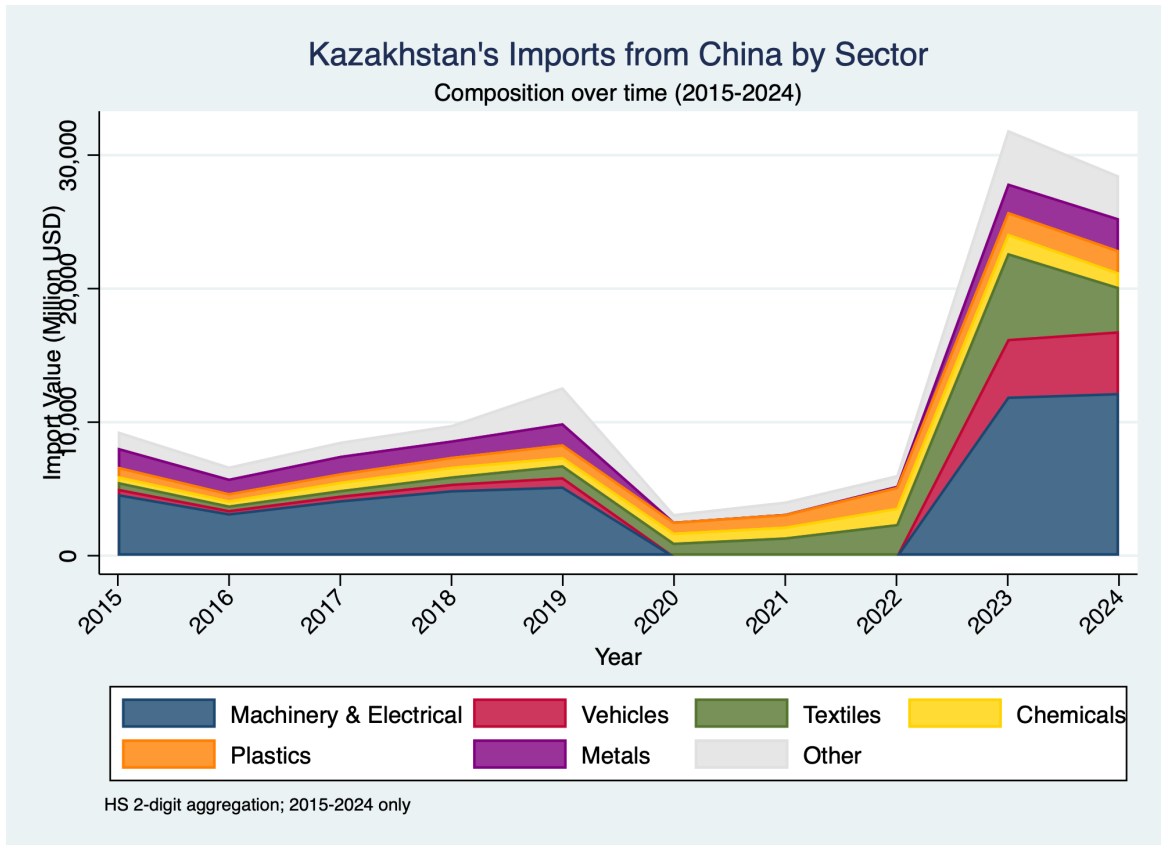


Figure 2: Kazakhstan's Imports from China by Sector, 2015-2024
Machinery (30%), vehicles (20%), and textiles (15%) dominate imports. Total grew 263% from \$6.2B to \$22.5B—2.3x faster than exports.
KEY INSIGHT: The 263% import surge (vs 120% export growth) creates the asymmetry driving the 2023 trade deficit.

Figure 6: Import composition from China (existing project figure).

4.3 Trade Balance, Deficits, and Vulnerabilities

The major shift is the transition from sustained pre-2023 bilateral surpluses to deficits in 2023 and 2024. This is consistent with faster post-2022 import growth relative to export growth.



Figure 13: Aggregate Trade Balance Evolution, 2015-2024
Average surplus 2015-2022: +\$5.1B. Peak 2022: +\$13.8B. 2023: -\$4.0B. 2024: -\$0.5B. Total swing: \$17.8B.
KEY INSIGHT: Eight consecutive years of surpluses reversed to deficits in 2023-2024, marking clearest inflection point in the decade.

Figure 7: Bilateral trade balance dynamics (existing project figure).



Figure 8: Deficit/asymmetry trajectory (existing project figure).

4.4 Statistical Discrepancies and Data Politics

A recurring interpretation issue is denominator choice: partner shares computed in a restricted comparison set can imply stronger apparent concentration than shares measured against full world trade totals. The project's multivector and asymmetry figures illustrate this distinction.

5 Comparing China to Other Partners

5.1 China vs Russia

Existing outputs indicate distinct dependence mechanisms: China dominates selected manufacturing import channels, while Russia remains embedded through legacy regional inte-

gration and intermediate flows.

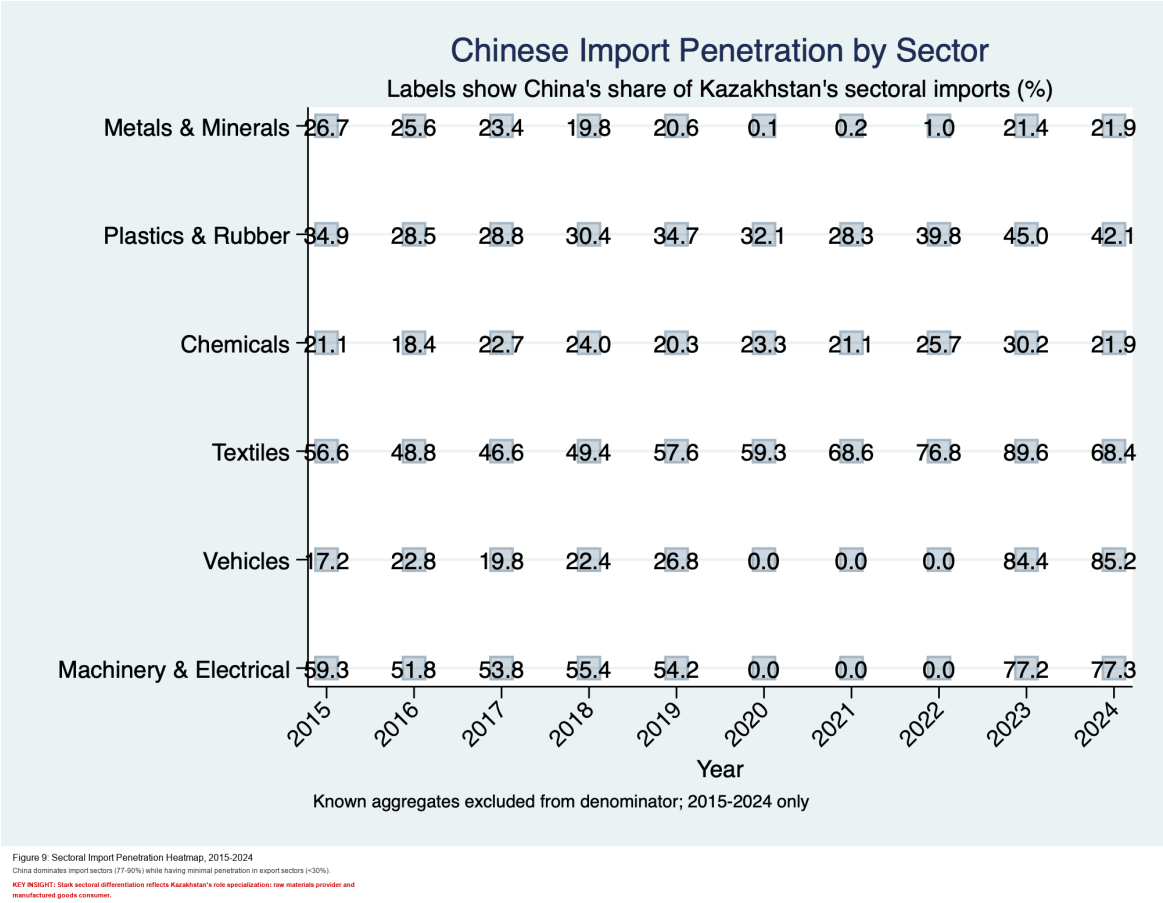


Figure 9: Sectoral penetration structure across categories (existing project figure).

5.2 China vs EU

The existing project narrative treats China and the EU as functionally different channels: China for high-volume manufactured supply and the EU for standards-intensive links and high-value export destinations.

5.3 Perceived Risks

Dependency concerns are tied to three interacting patterns visible in existing outputs: import concentration in key sectors, commodity-heavy export profile, and post-2023 balance deterioration. These patterns reinforce deindustrialization concerns unless offset by domestic upgrading and supplier diversification.

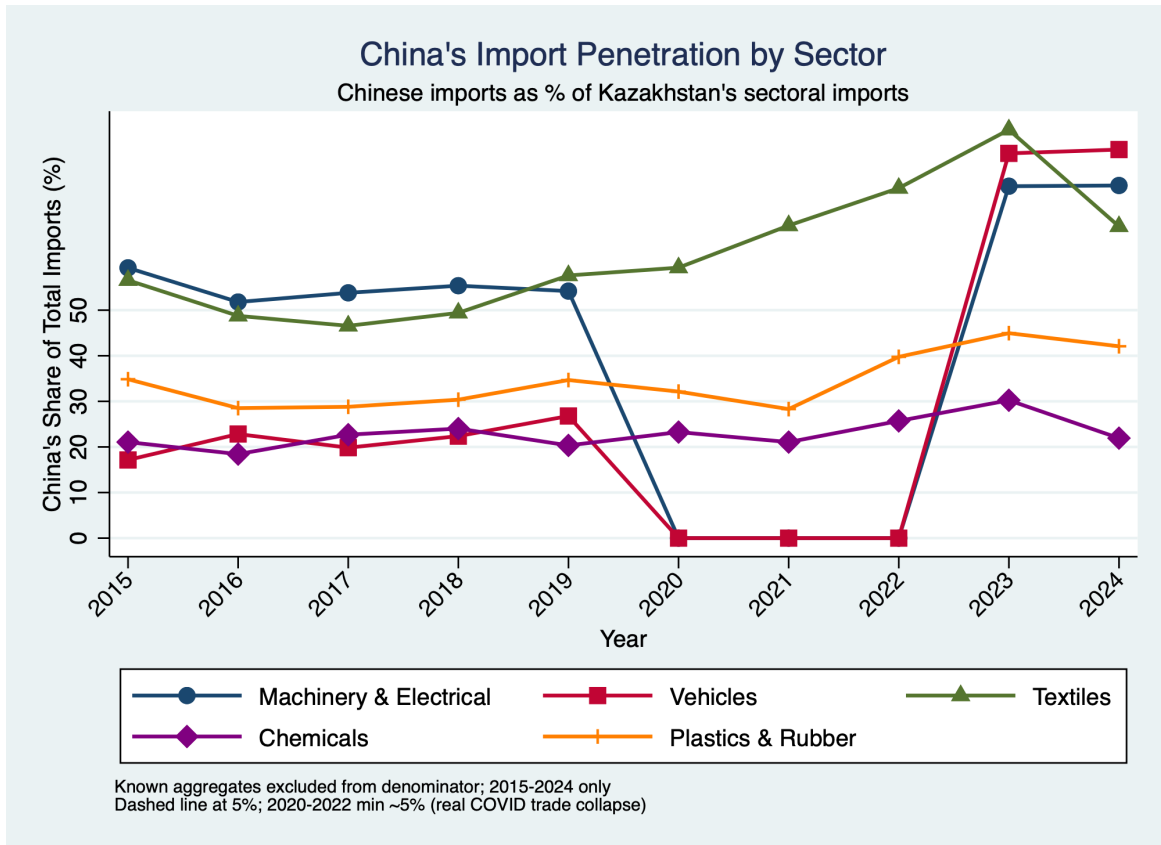


Figure 4: China's Import Penetration by Sector, 2015-2024
China supplies 77.3% of machinery, 64.5% of vehicles, and 89.8% of textile imports by 2023.
KEY INSIGHT: Extreme dominance in key sectors reflects supply chain concentration and limited domestic manufacturing capacity.

Figure 10: China import penetration and dependency concern (existing project figure).

6 Selected Summary Table (Existing Output)

Table 1: Kazakhstan–China Annual Bilateral Trade, 2015–2024 (existing project table)

Year	Exports (B\$)	Imports (B\$)	Balance (B\$)	Total (B\$)
2015	10.96	10.18	+0.78	21.14
2016	8.43	7.33	+1.10	15.75
2017	11.60	9.39	+2.21	20.99
2018	12.61	10.77	+1.85	23.38
2019	16.01	13.58	+2.43	29.58
2020	13.67	3.91	+9.76	17.58
2021	13.70	4.85	+8.86	18.55
2022	20.92	7.15	+13.77	28.07
2023	29.52	33.54	-4.03	63.06
2024	29.79	30.31	-0.51	60.10

7 Conclusion

Using only existing project outputs, the evidence supports four conclusions. First, 2023 is a structural inflection point in bilateral trade balance dynamics. Second, China’s role in Kazakhstan’s trade structure has deepened materially in the late period. Third, the relationship remains compositionally asymmetric (commodity exports versus manufactured imports). Fourth, vulnerability is concentrated in high-penetration sectors, implying that diversification and industrial upgrading are necessary for preserving multivector policy autonomy.